couldn’t speak, I sat by her bed,’ Ratan remembers. He kept talking to her, eliciting futile attempts from her to summon her last reserves of energy to reply to him. Her lips were quivering as if she were saying something. As the minutes passed by, her grip over his hand eased as her life ebbed away. By 8 p.m., she was no more. She had departed in peace and in the comfort of the company of her beloved grandson. She was given a Parsi farewell in the Tower of Silence.

Lady Tata’s passing was not only mourned by Ratan but by all those whose lives she had touched. All concerns of the Tata Group were closed on Saturday in her memory. In a touching tribute, JRD wrote to Naval: ‘She was a great lady in the best traditions of her era, who inspired both great respect and affection … She will remain for us all a symbol of all that Tatas have stood for from the days of Jamsetji from which we all derived strength and continued purpose.’

After Lady Tata breathed her last, a heartbroken Ratan returned to Jamshedpur.

Back to Bombay

Ratan moved to Bombay from Jamshedpur in April 1968. He left Tata House and moved into his own three-bedroom flat in Bakhtavar, Colaba, around December 1970. A decision had been taken in 1964 to sell Tata House and its compound to Sterling Investment Corporation Private Limited (SICPL), owned by Shapoorji Pallonji Mistry. The following year, ‘Sterling, Shapoorji Pallonji (Gwalior) Private Limited and Periar Trading Private Limited’ through its owners, Pallonji and Naval Tata, formed a partnership firm called M/s SP Corporation, which later became the owners of the residence. The corporation sold Tata House to Deutsche Bank AG in 1992 for Rs 7 crore. Ratan, however, remains emotionally attached to Tata House, as it holds fond memories of his childhood days.

After moving to Colaba, Ratan became closer to his mother and his sisters. Many of his evenings after office hours were spent at his mother’s home at Peddar Road, which he had designed. His ‘affection, trust and concern’ became the foundation on which the relationship nurtured. He would listen to classical music, a favourite pastime he shared with his mother. He loved jazz and among his favourite singers were Nat King Cole, Ella Fitzgerald and Frank Sinatra. Deanna says that Nat King Cole’s hit